

dence of partymen who are scouting for a future outside the party.

For a quarter century, the SAD-BJP alliance ran on a mutually beneficial formula that, going beyond poll arithmetic, also had a therapeutic effect. Yes, the BJP brought in the urban Hindu voters, the Akalis transacted with the rural Jat Sikh vote and the institutional heft of the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC). But this positioning also allowed the Badals to bring Sikh politics out of the shadow of pro-Khalistan militancy and reconsolidate under a more moderate umbrella in the mid-1990s. Sukhbir's father Parkash Singh Badal stitched the SAD back together, bringing in splinter factions led by Gurcharan Singh Tohra, Jagdev Singh Talwandi, Surjit Singh Barnala et al. Eventually, Captain Amarinder Singh's faction merged as well—before he rejoined the Congress a year later, in 1998.

Takeaways

- **SAD is trying to wangle a good deal in seat talks, showcasing '25 rural poll**
- **BJP says, based on 2022 and 2024 figures, it must get over 70 of 117 seats**
- **Wracked by rebellion, cast out by clergy, Sukhbir struggles to reclaim base**

A revival of that compact—and the memory of the stability it exuded for nearly two decades—could be life support for the SAD. Trouble is, its equations with the BJP have reversed. In 1997, the SAD could pull in 37.64 votes on its own; the BJP was the junior partner in a Sikh-centred polity, content to contest 23 seats in a 117-strong assembly. But the SAD has offered a sadder graph than the Sensex on a bad day: from 56 seats in 2012, it fell to 15 in 2017, and three in 2022, when Sukhbir lost even stronghold Jalalabad. In the 2024 Lok Sabha poll, it won only Bathinda, forfeited its deposit in 11 of 13 seats and polled 13.42 per cent votes. The BJP, fighting alone for the first time since 1996, won nothing but polled 18.56 per cent.

The tone of negotiations has naturally changed. Sukhbir wants the SAD-BJP seat split worked out from an average of the past three polls—including the village-level polls of last year where its relatively better performance equalises some of its lost weight at the higher levels. But the BJP has analysed the 2022 and 2024 results to divide the state into seats of relative dominance. Based on that, it reportedly wants more than 70 of 117 and has hardened its public stance. Union minister Hardeep Singh Puri, the party's senior-most Sikh face, said in Amritsar on September 19 that the BJP would not ally with the SAD—unless it was on equal terms. "The earlier 23-seat formula will no longer work," he noted.

THE JAT SIKH OVERTURE

The BJP has also changed its composition. Its Punjab unit is now led by a Jat Sikh, Kewal Singh Dhillon. In gubernatorial perches and the like, it has placed several members of that powerful group, once a monopoly of the Akalis. On the political front, Major Bhupinder Singh Dhillon (retd), Badal Sr's cousin and political secretary for 25 years, joined the BJP with his son on September 14—he may be fielded from Lambi, the family seat.

The BJP has limited stake in the panthic world, but the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) harbours a larger ambition: to become part of the global Sikh narrative, making inroads into the diaspora in Canada, the US, the UK and Germany. For the BJP-RSS, an alliance must help, not hinder its objectives. For now, the bargain looks sharper than a kirpan's edge for Sukhbir. ■

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

A BEETLE ROCKS THE FOREST

The central India jungles are seeing a bounty hunt: for the Sal borer, nemesis of the majestic Sal tree

By **Rahul Noronha**

A BEETLE, ABOUT THE SIZE OF A HUMAN FINGER, is threatening to wipe out entire forests. Yes, the dreaded sal borer, which carries the appropriately thorny-sounding scientific name *Hoplocerambyx spinicornis*, has made a comeback in Dindori district of eastern Madhya Pradesh. It's giving nightmares to the state forest department because this little insect can be the nemesis for vast forest swathes populated by the Sal tree, *Shorea robusta*, drilling holes right into its majestic trunk. The total area affected is presently around 30,000 hectares, spread over three ranges: East Karanjia, West Karanjia and Samnapur. Forest officials have scrambled to put in place measures to control the beetle, and have

Takeaways

- **The tiny Sal borer, a beetle that can destroy entire Sal forests, wreaks havoc in MP**
- **The larva drills right through to the heart of the trunk while feeding on sapwood**
- **The timber loses value, loss of foliage harms ecology; locals fielded to trap beetle**